

PART – A (5 × 2 = 10 Marks)

Q1. Define cognitive skills.

[2 Marks]

Cognitive skills are the core mental abilities the brain uses to think, read, learn, remember, reason, and pay attention. They include perception, memory, logical reasoning, processing speed, and language comprehension, enabling individuals to acquire knowledge and solve problems effectively.

Q2. What are non-cognitive skills?

[2 Marks]

Non-cognitive skills are personal attributes and social-emotional competencies not related to intellectual ability. They include self-discipline, motivation, resilience, empathy, teamwork, and emotional intelligence — focusing on how we manage ourselves and relate to others, and are crucial for workplace success and well-being.

Q3. List any two types of cognitive skills.

[2 Marks]

- **Sustained Attention:** The ability to focus on a task for a prolonged period without distraction.
- **Working Memory:** The ability to hold and manipulate information in the mind over short periods, essential for reasoning.

Q4. What do you mean by empathy?

[2 Marks]

Empathy is the ability to understand and share the feelings and experiences of another person. It has two dimensions: *cognitive empathy* (understanding another's perspective intellectually) and *affective empathy* (feeling what another feels). It is foundational for communication, teamwork, and strong interpersonal relationships.

Q5. Mention any two stress management techniques.

[2 Marks]

- **Deep Breathing:** Slow diaphragmatic breaths activate the parasympathetic nervous system, quickly reducing stress symptoms.
- **Time Management:** Organising tasks using priority lists and schedules reduces feelings of overwhelm — a major cause of stress.

PART – B (3 × 7 = 21 Marks)

Q1. Explain the importance of cognitive skills in the workplace. Also discuss strategies to improve them.

[7 Marks]

Importance in the Workplace: Cognitive skills form the intellectual backbone of professional performance. Strong cognitive abilities enable employees to analyse complex problems, make sound decisions, learn new technologies rapidly, communicate effectively, and manage time efficiently. They directly impact productivity, adaptability, and career growth.

- **Problem Solving & Decision Making:** Logical reasoning and critical thinking help evaluate options and devise effective solutions to workplace challenges.
- **Learning & Adaptability:** High cognitive skills allow workers to quickly master new tools, adapt to industry changes, and upskill with ease.
- **Attention to Detail:** Sustained attention reduces errors in precision tasks such as data analysis, accounting, or engineering.

Strategies to Improve Cognitive Skills:

- **Mental Exercises:** Puzzles, chess, brain-training apps, and reading stimulate neural pathways and improve memory and reasoning.
- **Continuous Learning:** Courses, workshops, and certifications challenge the brain and build cognitive reserves.
- **Physical Exercise & Sleep:** Aerobic exercise increases blood flow to the brain; 7–8 hours of sleep consolidates memory and restores cognitive function.
- **Mindfulness & Nutrition:** Meditation improves focused attention; a diet rich in omega-3 and antioxidants supports brain health.

Q2. Discuss the stages of problem-solving and explain any two obstacles in problem-solving.

[7 Marks]

Stages of Problem-Solving:

- **1. Identify the Problem:** Clearly define the issue with specificity — a well-defined problem is halfway solved.
- **2. Analyse the Problem:** Break it into components; understand causes, scope, and affected parties.
- **3. Generate Solutions:** Brainstorm multiple options without judgement, encouraging creative thinking.
- **4. Evaluate & Select:** Assess options on feasibility, resources, and potential outcomes; choose the best solution.
- **5. Implement:** Execute the solution with a clear plan, defined roles, and timeline.
- **6. Review & Reflect:** Evaluate results and restart the process if the problem persists.

Two Obstacles in Problem-Solving:

- **1. Mental Set (Fixedness):** The tendency to keep using a previously successful strategy even when it is no longer appropriate. This prevents exploration of creative alternatives. *Example:* An engineer who always uses a familiar formula may fail when a novel approach is required.
- **2. Confirmation Bias:** The tendency to seek and interpret information that confirms pre-existing beliefs while ignoring contradictory evidence. *Example:* A manager who believes an employee is underperforming may notice only negative results and overlook positive contributions, leading to flawed decisions.

Q3. Explain the concept of non-cognitive skills. Discuss any three types with suitable examples.

[7 Marks]

Non-cognitive skills are attitudes, behaviours, and social-emotional competencies that complement intellectual ability. Research by psychologists like Angela Duckworth shows that traits such as grit and self-control often predict long-term success better than IQ alone. They are vital for academic achievement, career success, and life satisfaction.

Three Types with Examples:

- **1. Emotional Intelligence (EI):** The ability to understand, manage, and express one's own emotions and respond sensitively to others'. *Example:* A manager notices a demotivated team member, has a private conversation, and adjusts workload — boosting morale and retention.

2. Self-Discipline and Grit: The ability to control impulses and persist towards long-term goals despite setbacks. *Example:* A student who consistently prepares over several weeks (not just the night before exams) demonstrates self-discipline; an entrepreneur who bounces back from multiple failures demonstrates grit.

3. Communication & Interpersonal Skills: The ability to express ideas clearly, listen actively, and build positive relationships. *Example:* A sales professional who listens to a client's concerns and offers a tailored solution demonstrates strong interpersonal skills — closing the deal and building a lasting relationship.

PART – C (3 × 11 = 33 Marks)

Q1. Discuss in detail the types of cognitive skills. Explain the role of critical thinking and the ability to learn in personal and professional life.

[11 Marks]

Types of Cognitive Skills:

- **Sustained Attention:** Focusing on a task for an extended period without distraction — essential for surgery, coding, or detailed analysis.
- **Working Memory:** Temporarily holding and manipulating information (e.g., following multi-step instructions). Critical for comprehension and reasoning.
- **Long-Term Memory:** Storing and retrieving information over time — includes episodic (personal events) and semantic (facts/concepts) memory.
- **Processing Speed:** How quickly the brain interprets and responds to information, enabling rapid decision-making in fast-paced environments.
- **Logical Reasoning:** Systematic analysis to draw valid conclusions — inductive (general from specific) and deductive (specific from general).
- **Visual & Auditory Processing:** Accurate interpretation of images and sounds — crucial for reading, listening, and spatial awareness.
- **Executive Functions:** Higher-order processes including planning, organising, impulse control, and cognitive flexibility governing goal-directed behaviour.

Role of Critical Thinking: Critical thinking is the disciplined, objective analysis of an issue to form sound judgements. It involves questioning assumptions and evaluating evidence from multiple perspectives.

- *Personal Life:* Enables informed decisions about health, finances, and relationships; protects against misinformation; promotes self-reflection and growth.
- *Professional Life:* Helps evaluate business problems objectively, drives innovation by challenging conventional approaches, and improves persuasive communication. Employers consistently rank it among the most desired workplace skills.

Role of the Ability to Learn (Learnability): Learnability is the capacity and willingness to acquire new knowledge and skills continuously — arguably the most crucial cognitive skill in a rapidly changing world.

- *Personal Life:* Helps adapt to new circumstances; supports intellectual curiosity and resilience; enables recovery from setbacks through acquired knowledge.
- *Professional Life:* Enables upskilling as industries evolve, accelerates career growth, and drives organisational competitiveness. Companies with a strong learning culture consistently outperform competitors in innovation and employee retention.

Q2. Elaborate on the concept of teamwork and collaboration. Explain their importance, advantages, and strategies to handle conflicts in a team.

[11 Marks]

Teamwork is the cooperative effort of a group working towards a shared goal through coordinated tasks, shared responsibilities, and mutual support. **Collaboration** is a deeper form where members actively co-create solutions through joint problem-solving and integrated effort — producing outcomes superior to individual work.

Importance:

- **Synergy:** Collaborative teams produce results greater than the sum of individual efforts (1+1=3 in productivity).
- **Diverse Perspectives:** Teams blend different expertise and viewpoints, leading to more innovative, comprehensive solutions.
- **Shared Workload & Accountability:** Tasks are distributed by strengths, reducing burnout; members motivate each other to maintain standards.
- **Skill Development:** Exposure to colleagues' approaches builds capabilities individuals would not develop alone.

Advantages: Faster project completion through parallel working; higher quality outputs via peer review; increased employee engagement and job satisfaction; better risk identification; stronger organisational culture built on trust.

Strategies to Handle Team Conflicts:

- **Open Communication:** Create a safe space for respectful disagreement — suppressed conflicts breed resentment; dialogue resolves them.
- **Active Listening:** Ensure all parties feel genuinely heard before proposing solutions; many conflicts stem from simple misunderstandings.
- **Focus on Issues, Not Personalities:** Address the behaviour/situation, not personal traits, to reduce defensiveness.
- **Seek Win-Win Solutions:** Collaborative problem-solving that addresses both parties' core needs produces durable resolutions.
- **Mediation & Clear Roles:** Involve a neutral party for serious disputes; prevent conflicts by defining responsibilities clearly from the outset.

Q3. Write a detailed note on stress and stress management. Explain causes of stress and various techniques to manage stress effectively.

[11 Marks]

What is Stress? Stress is the body's physiological and psychological response to perceived demands that exceed available coping resources. It activates the 'fight-or-flight' response, releasing cortisol and adrenaline. Short-term (acute) stress can sharpen focus; chronic stress is harmful to physical and mental health.

Types of Stress:

- **Eustress (Positive):** Mild, motivating stress — excitement before a presentation or competition.
- **Distress (Negative):** Overwhelming stress that impairs functioning and well-being.
- **Acute vs. Chronic:** Acute stress is short-term and resolves quickly; chronic stress persists over time and is most damaging to health.

Causes of Stress:

- **Academic/Professional:** Heavy workload, tight deadlines, job insecurity, workplace conflicts, lack of autonomy.
- **Personal/Social:** Financial difficulties, relationship problems, major life changes (relocation, bereavement), health concerns.
- **Environmental:** Information overload, social media, noise, overcrowding, or traumatic events.

Effects of Chronic Stress: Physically — headaches, high blood pressure, weakened immunity, insomnia. Psychologically — anxiety, depression, poor concentration. Behaviourally — social withdrawal, unhealthy habits, reduced productivity.

Stress Management Techniques:

Physical Techniques:

- **Regular Exercise:** Releases endorphins — natural mood elevators. Even 30 minutes of brisk walking daily significantly reduces stress hormones.
- **Deep Breathing & PMR:** Diaphragmatic breathing activates the parasympathetic system; Progressive Muscle Relaxation releases physical tension stored in the body.
- **Adequate Sleep:** 7–8 hours allows the brain to process emotions and restore stress resilience.

Cognitive/Psychological Techniques:

- **Cognitive Restructuring:** Identifying and replacing negative thought patterns with balanced, realistic perspectives.
- **Mindfulness Meditation:** Present-moment awareness reduces rumination and anxiety — even 10 minutes daily produces measurable benefits.
- **Journaling:** Writing about stressors helps process emotions and identify recurring triggers.

Lifestyle Techniques:

- **Time Management:** Priority lists and the Eisenhower Matrix reduce overwhelm caused by disorganisation and procrastination.
- **Social Support:** Talking to trusted friends, family, or counsellors provides emotional relief and perspective.
- **Hobbies & Professional Help:** Leisure activities replenish emotional energy; CBT therapy offers structured, evidence-based relief for severe stress.

Stress is unavoidable, but manageable. By combining physical, cognitive, and lifestyle strategies, individuals can transform stress from a debilitating force into a manageable challenge — a skill that pays lifelong dividends in

health and professional success.